Fideicide, Occupation, and the Eidolic Apocalypse in Andrzej Żuławski's Possession *(1981)*

A dissertation toward a tychastic theology of the divided city

Sister Chance



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Abstract

This dissertation argues that Andrzej Żuławski's *Possession* (1981) is not, in the first instance, a horror film about a possessed woman but a work of speculative theology whose object is possession itself, and whose plot is the passage from an order of *fides* to an order of *tyche*: from a world in which persons, bodies, and territories are held by faith, covenant, and title to a world in which they are held only by occupation and chance. The pivot of that passage is the film's most notorious sequence, in which Anna, in a pedestrian passage of the Berlin U-Bahn, undergoes a convulsive expulsion she later names the miscarriage of "Sister Faith," from which only "Sister Chance" survives. Read here as a *fideicide*, the event expels faith in four registers at once — theological (*pistis*), conjugal (fidelity), juridical (*bona fides*), and diplomatic (the good faith of treaties) — and it takes place beneath the monument to the airlift that kept an occupied city alive.

The German of the film's setting gathers the possessions it stages under the root *sitzen*, "to sit": *Besitz* (ownership); *Besessenheit* (demonic possession, *besessen* being the past participle of *besitzen*); *Besetzung* (Freudian cathexis, but also squatting, military occupation, and theatrical casting); and *Besatzung* (the four-power occupation of Berlin). The dissertation names their convergence the *Besetzung complex* and demonstrates that the film renders the four as a single act. Reading the creature tautegorically — as meaning what it shows — before reading it allegorically, it reconstructs the creature's genealogy through Valentinian Gnosticism (Sophia's abortive offspring; the Limit called Cross), the myths of Pasiphaë, Enkidu, and Salmacis, and the modern teratologies of Lovecraft, Machen, Schulz, and Lem; and it reconstructs the film's doubles through the Stesichorean phantom of Helen, Amphitryon, Hoffmann, Poe, Dostoevsky, Rank, Villiers de l'Isle-Adam, and Jean Paul's *Siebenkäs*, the novel about escaping a marriage in which the word *Doppelgänger* was coined. The film is situated within Żuławski's

biography (a father who survived the occupation of Lwów feeding lice for Rudolf Weigl's typhus vaccine; the destruction of *On the Silver Globe*; the end of a marriage), within the Polish metaphysical tradition from Mickiewicz and Krasiński to Witkacy, Gombrowicz, Schulz, and Grotowski, and within the strategic culture of the late Cold War: Thomas Schelling's "threat that leaves something to chance," Herman Kahn's escalation ladder, NATO's *Doppelbeschluss*.

The original contribution is a theory of *eidolic usucapion*. Under a regime of chance, whatever is held without faith must be held by occupation; occupation generates a counterfeit of what it holds; and the counterfeit, by uninterrupted possession, acquires title. Kant's definition of marriage as the "lifelong reciprocal possession" (*Besitz*) of sexual attributes — a right to persons "akin to a right to things" — is shown to secrete, at its limit, the Thing itself. The final scene, in which the perfected doubles of the dead spouses meet at a threshold while the child submerges and sirens announce war, is read as the moment the eidolon takes title over the real: Mark without the mark. From this reading the dissertation derives twelve theses toward a *tychastic theology* of the divided city, and proposes *eidolic horror* — the horror of the surplus double that lacks the lack — as a category distinct from both abject horror (Kristeva, Creed) and the paranoid horror of the deficient copy (the body-snatcher tradition).

Note on Method, Sources, and Conventions

Object. The text examined is the complete version of *Possession* (approximately 124 minutes), a Franco–West German co-production produced by Marie-Laure Reyre, written by Andrzej Żuławski with Frederic Tuten, photographed by Bruno Nuytten, scored by Andrzej Korzyński, with creature effects by Carlo Rambaldi. It was shot in West Berlin in 1980 and premiered in competition at Cannes in May 1981, where Isabelle Adjani received the award for Best Actress (jointly honouring her performance in James Ivory's *Quartet*). The drastically shortened and reordered American release of 1983, like the film's absorption into Britain's "video nasties" panic, belongs to its reception history and is not analysed as the work.

Method. The dissertation proceeds by a doubled reading. Schelling, crediting the coinage to Coleridge, held that mythology is not allegorical but *tautegorical*: its gods do not stand for something else; they mean what they are. The creature is accordingly read first tautegorically — as an event the film insists on showing, feeding, and completing — and only then allegorically, as a figure of divorce, of the divided city, of the bloc system. The two readings are kept in parallel rather than reconciled, on the principle that the method should be the double of its object: as the film declines to decide between Anna's hysteria and Anna's theophany, the analysis declines to dissolve the literal into the figurative. The choice is also polemical. The prevailing interpretation — that *Possession* is "really" about its director's divorce — is biographically warranted and hermeneutically inert: it explains why the film was made and nothing about what it does.

Grades of relation. Three kinds of connection are distinguished throughout. *Documented affinity* designates sources Żuławski demonstrably engaged: Dostoevsky, whose *Demons* he staged within *La Femme*

publique (1984); the Polish Romantic canon; his great-uncle Jerzy Żuławski; his own earlier films. *Cultural substrate* designates texts constitutive of the formation of a Polish and European intellectual of his generation — Mickiewicz, Krasiński, Goethe, Kleist — whose presence need not be intended to be operative. *Structural affinity* designates comparisons for which no influence is claimed — Valentinus, Peirce, Thomas Schelling — adduced because they render the film's logic legible. Onomastic and topographic coincidences (the two Schellings, the Heinrich constellation, the name Kreuzberg) are treated as constellations in Walter Benjamin's sense: configurations whose legibility is historical rather than authorial.

Conventions. Characters are named as in the film: Mark (Sam Neill), Anna and Helen (both Isabelle Adjani), Heinrich (Heinz Bennent), Margit (Margit Carstensen), Bob (Michael Hogben). The creature's terminal form, the replica of Mark, is designated Mark′. Classical, patristic, and juridical texts are cited by standard reference; modern works by author and year of first publication, page references omitted. Translations from German, Latin, Greek, Polish, and French are the author's own. Quotations and dates in this draft have not been collated against specific editions and should be verified before citation. Dialogue from the film is paraphrased, save for the two names on which the argument turns. Scene descriptions follow the complete cut; where the film is ambiguous, the ambiguity is reported rather than resolved.

Introduction

The Fourfold Possession



nec duo sunt, sed forma duplex

Ovid, *Metamorphoses* IV

"his little heart, dispossessed, had stopped"

Henry James, *The Turn of the Screw*

1 *The problem*

Possession has had the reception its title predicts: it has been owned, disowned, and repossessed. Cut by its American distributor into near-incoherence, swept into Britain's "video nasties" panic, dismissed by much of the contemporary press as hysterical excess, it has since been reclaimed by restoration, repertory programming, and a growing critical literature as one of the singular works of European cinema. That literature has converged on three readings, each correct and none sufficient. The *autobiographical* reading derives the film from the dissolution of Żuławski's marriage; the *political* reading derives it from its location, an apartment overlooking the Wall, and from its spy-husband; the *somatic* reading places it beside David Cronenberg's *The Brood* and Ridley Scott's *Alien* (both 1979) as a document of the body-horror imagination of its moment. All three share a premise: that the creature is a metaphor. The film's wager is the opposite. The creature is shown, fed, protected, killed for, made love to, and completed; it acquires a face; it walks. A reading that cannot take that literalism seriously has decided in advance the question the film exists to pose.

This dissertation takes the title at its word. *Possession* is a film about possession — not one possession but four, and about the discovery that the four are one.

2 *The Besetzung complex*

English *possess* descends from Latin *possidere*, compounded of *potis*, "master, able," and *sedere*, "to sit": the possessor is the one who sits as master upon what he holds. The German of the film's setting preserves the posture with unusual completeness. *Besitzen*, "to sit upon," yields *Besitz*, ownership; its past participle, *besessen*, is the ordinary word for the demonically possessed, so that in German to be possessed and to be owned are grammatically one participle. *Besetzung* denotes the military occupation of a place, the squatting of a house (*Hausbesetzung*), the casting of a role, and — in the Freudian lexicon, where James Strachey rendered it "cathexis" — the investment of an object with libidinal energy. *Besatzung*

names the occupying power itself. In West Berlin in 1980, every one of these senses was literally in force.

Register	German term	Classical or juridical analogue	Locus in the film
Proprietary and conjugal	*Besitz*	*possessio*, *dominium*	Mark's claim on Anna; Kant's "reciprocal possession" of spouses
Demonic	*Besessenheit*	*possessio diabolica*, *obsessio*	Anna and the creature; the convulsion
Libidinal	*Besetzung* (cathexis)	—	the creature and Helen as invested objects
Geopolitical	*Besatzung*, *Besetzung*	*occupatio*	the four-power city; the Wall; the watchtower; the Kreuzberg squats
Theatrical	*Besetzung* (casting)	*persona*	Adjani's double role; the actor possessed by the part

I call the convergence of these registers the *Besetzung complex*. Its claim is that holding, being held, investing, and occupying are modes of a single act — sitting upon an other — and that *Possession* is the most rigorous cinematic demonstration of their identity.

3 *The argument in four propositions*

First, fideicide. The U-Bahn sequence is not a symptom but an event: the expulsion of faith from the body of the world. Faith is expelled in every register in which possession can be grounded — theological faith (*pistis*), conjugal fidelity, juridical good faith (*bona fides*), the diplomatic good faith of treaties.

Second, tychocracy. What survives the expulsion is not a void but a sister: Chance. Chance is an order — the order of the wager (Pascal), of the indifferent universe (Monod), of evolution by fortuitous variation (Peirce), and of deterrence, which Thomas Schelling defined by "the threat that leaves something to chance." The Cold War is a tychocracy, and the marriage is its miniature.

Third, the law of the double. Whatever is held without faith must be held by occupation, and occupation doubles what it holds. An occupied city becomes two cities; an occupied marriage becomes two marriages. The double is not a symptom of possession but its form under a regime of chance.

Fourth, eidolic usucapion. The double, by uninterrupted possession, acquires title — in bad faith, against every principle of the law of possession, which is why it appears as a monster. When it does, the world ends. The final scene, in which the perfected copies of the dead spouses meet at a threshold while sirens announce war, stages the accession of the eidolon to the place of the real: Mark without the mark.

4 *Against allegory, with tautegory*

Fredric Jameson's injunction to "always historicize," issued in *The Political Unconscious* in the year of the film's release, is honoured here: the film is a socially symbolic act whose contradictions are those of the divided city in the season of the Euromissiles. But the film resists the allegorical decoding historicism usually performs, because its central sign is not a symbol but a body. The resistance has a precise generic consequence. Robin Wood's celebrated formula for the horror film — normality threatened by the Monster — presupposes that the monster is normality's other. In *Possession* the monster's telos is normality itself, perfected: a husband without flaw, calm-eyed, silent, complete. The monster does not threaten the norm; it becomes it. This inversion is the film's scandal and the reason it has fitted no existing taxonomy of horror. Chapter VI proposes one.

5 *Architecture*

Chapter II establishes the film's genealogies — biographical, Polish-literary, and festival-historical. Chapter III reconstructs the theology of the underpass. Chapter IV reads Anna's convulsion against the archive of hysteria, possession, and ecstatic performance. Chapter V reconstructs the creature's teratogony. Chapter VI derives the law of the double and

proposes the category of eidolic horror. Chapter VII reads the marriage through the law of possession, from Kant and Savigny to Roman usucapion. Chapter VIII situates the whole in the divided city and the strategic theory of the late Cold War. Chapter IX interprets the ending as a counterfeit eschaton. Chapter X condenses the argument into twelve theses; the Conclusion and Coda return to the sister the film never names.

Genealogies

Lice, Moons, Divorce, and the Polish Metaphysical Inheritance



Even the name survives the transposition. Helena becomes Helen.

1 *The louse-feeder's son*

Andrzej Żuławski was born in Lwów in November 1940, under Soviet occupation; before his fourth birthday the city had passed to German occupation and back. His father, the writer Mirosław Żuławski, survived the German years as one of the louse-feeders of Rudolf Weigl's institute, where the production of an anti-typhus vaccine required human hosts to nourish infected lice with their own blood — employment that sheltered a significant part of the city's intelligentsia. The experience became the substance of the son's first feature, *Trzecia część nocy* (*The Third Part of the Night*, 1971), written with his father, whose title is taken from Revelation 8:12, where the fourth trumpet darkens a third of the sun, the moon, the stars, the day, and the night.

The primal image of corporeal possession in Żuławski's work is thus historical before it is fantastic: a body under occupation feeding an alien organism with its blood so that something may be manufactured from it. Anna, feeding a creature in a flat on the edge of an occupied city, repeats the figure under inverted signs — the product is not immunity but a god. *The Third Part of the Night* contains, in embryo, the grammar of the later film. Its protagonist, whose wife Helena is murdered, encounters a woman identical to her, Marta — both played by Małgorzata Braunek; a stranger is arrested in his place, a double who dies for him; a childbirth is filmed with an intensity that anticipates the underpass. A doubled woman, a doubled man, birth as catastrophe, apocalypse as title: *Possession* was already written, in another key, a decade earlier. Even the name survives the transposition. Helena becomes Helen.

2 *The sabotaged messiah*

Żuławski's great-uncle Jerzy Żuławski published, between 1903 and 1911, the *Lunar Trilogy*, in which colonists from Earth found a society on the Moon whose descendants turn their origin into a religion and await a redeemer. The great-nephew's adaptation, *Na srebrnym globie* (*On the Silver Globe*), was halted in 1977 on the order of the deputy minister of culture, Janusz Wilhelmi, with most of the principal photography complete; Żu-

ławski left for France, and the surviving footage was assembled only a decade later, its lacunae bridged by his voice-over across images of contemporary Polish streets. In the film, the arrival from Earth — an astronaut named Marek — is received as the messiah and ends crucified by those who acclaimed him.

Possession is the work of the exile that followed the destruction of a messianic film, and its protagonist bears the anglicized name of the crucified astronaut. The coincidence acquires weight once one notices where Mark lives: in the district whose name means "Cross Hill." The sabotaged epic of a messiah who fails on the Moon is succeeded by a domestic film in which faith is miscarried within sight of a frontier — and what is born there takes the name of the crucified.

3 *The divorce as primal scene*

Braunek, the lead of Żuławski's first two features, separated from him in the mid-1970s and turned for many years from the screen toward Zen practice, of which she became a teacher. The director's own repeated account locates the conception of *Possession* in that rupture, and Heinrich — whose patter of cosmic energies, bodily liberation, and serene nonattachment belongs to the West German reception of the guru culture of the late 1970s — has accordingly been read as its caricature. The reading is not wrong, but it is too easy; Chapter III argues that Heinrich's function is theological rather than satirical.

The structural comparison is with Cronenberg's *The Brood* (1979), likewise conceived amid its director's divorce and custody dispute, in which a woman under "psychoplasmic" therapy externalizes her rage as asexual offspring borne in a sac outside her body. Both films convert a marriage's dissolution into teratogenesis. But Cronenberg's monstrous children are the mother's rage — a pathology; Żuławski's creature is the wife's desire — a theology. *The Brood* ends with the affliction passing to the daughter; *Possession* ends with the son seeking refuge under water from what stands at the door.

4 *The Polish metaphysical inheritance*

Żuławski's cinema is the most direct heir of the Polish Romantic drama of metaphysical frenzy, and *Possession* rehearses its central configurations with a precision that does not require intention to be demonstrable.

Adam Mickiewicz's *Dziady* (*Forefathers' Eve*) is organized around rites of possession. In Part II, the shepherdess Zosia, who in life never loved, is barred from heaven: "Kto nie dotknął ziemi ni razu, / Ten nigdy nie może być w niebie" — whoever has not touched the earth even once can never be in heaven. Helen, the ethereal double who has touched nothing, is Zosia; Anna is the woman who has touched the earth to excess. In Part IV the lover Gustaw, maddened by the loss of his beloved to a richer match, performs a theatrical suicide; in Part III an inscription records the transformation — *Gustavus obiit… hic natus est Conradus* — of the lover into the political prophet, whose Great Improvisation challenges God and ends in a possession, a demon finishing the blasphemy the poet left unsaid, before the priest Piotr exorcises him. The national drama's crisis is a possession; its hero is reborn out of erotic catastrophe into the political.

Zygmunt Krasiński's *Nie-Boska komedia* (*The Un-Divine Comedy*, 1835) supplies the structural template. Its protagonist — designated in the dramatis personae simply as the Husband, Count Henryk — is lured from his wife by the Maiden, a phantom of ideal femininity sent by infernal powers, who discloses herself as a corpse. The wife goes mad and dies; the son is born sickly, goes blind, and becomes a visionary; and the domestic catastrophe opens without transition onto a revolutionary apocalypse in which the old world ends. A husband, a phantom ideal woman, a maddened wife, a damaged son, a world in flames — and a Henryk. *Possession* is the Un-Divine Comedy of the Cold War.

Juliusz Słowacki's *Balladyna* (written 1834) provides the sisters: the dark, ambitious Balladyna kills her gentle sister Alina for the hand of the lord Kirkor, and bears ever after a stain on her forehead that cannot be washed away — a mark. Stanisław Wyspiański's *Wesele* (*The Wedding*, 1901), filmed in 1972 by Andrzej Wajda, under whom Żuławski had served his apprenticeship, visits a wedding with phantoms who are the guests' doubles and ends in the Straw Man's somnambulist dance of na-

tional paralysis. *Possession* is its antithesis: a marriage visited by its doubles that dances not into paralysis but into convulsion.

The interwar catastrophists supply the diagnosis. Stanisław Ignacy Witkiewicz's *Nienasycenie* (*Insatiability*, 1930) imagines the pill of Murti-Bing, which dissolves metaphysical anguish and reconciles its takers to conquest; Czesław Miłosz, in *The Captive Mind* (1953), made the pill the emblem of the intellectual's accommodation to Stalinism and added *Ketman*, the art of living a double life under surveillance. Heinrich is Murti-Bing; Mark, the professional dissembler, is Ketman. Witold Gombrowicz contributes the theory of Form imposed by others — the "mug" (*gęba*) pinned on one's face — and, in the dream-play *Ślub* (*The Marriage*, 1953), a returning soldier named Henryk who finds his home degraded and his fiancée debased and attempts to consecrate his own marriage through a divinity generated between people: the interhuman church. *Possession*'s creature is precisely a god born between people. Żuławski's last film would adapt Gombrowicz's *Kosmos* (2015), a novel of paranoid sign-reading. Bruno Schulz's "Treatise on Tailors' Dummies, or the Second Book of Genesis" (1934) grants the heretical Father a demiurgy without monopoly, a matter of infinite fecundity eager to take any form, and a second creation of humanity in the image of the dummy; his Street of Crocodiles is the counterfeit quarter of a provincial city, a district of imitation and shoddy modernity — a figure, avant la lettre, for West Berlin, the shop window of the West.

The theatre supplies the method. Jerzy Grotowski's "total act," the self-sacrificial exposure of the "holy actor" exemplified by Ryszard Cieślak in *The Constant Prince* (1965), is the nearest analogue to Adjani's underpass. And Jerzy Kawalerowicz's *Matka Joanna od Aniołów* (*Mother Joan of the Angels*, 1961, after Jarosław Iwaszkiewicz), which relocates the Loudun possessions to a Polish convent, ends with the exorcist Suryn murdering two innocents so that the prioress's demons may pass into him — possession transferred, by love, to the man who would cure it. Mark's trajectory, from agent of order to murderer in his wife's service, is Suryn's.

Possession also completes an émigré triptych. Roman Polański's *Repulsion* (1965) and *The Tenant* (1976) — in which a timid émigré of Polish ori-

gin, in a Paris flat, is progressively possessed by the identity of the woman who preceded him there — and Jerzy Skolimowski's *The Shout* (1978), in which a stranger's magic takes possession of a marriage, constitute with Żuławski's film a Polish exile cinema of the occupied apartment.

5 *Cannes, May 1981: two theologies*

At the 1981 Cannes festival the Palme d'Or went to Wajda's *Człowiek z żelaza* (*Man of Iron*), the film of Solidarity, whose sacramental centre is a wedding at which Lech Wałęsa stands witness: marriage as a public act of faith, two years after John Paul II, in Warsaw, had prayed for the Spirit to descend and renew the face of "this earth." At the same festival Adjani was named Best Actress for a film about the miscarriage of faith. Two Polish theologies faced each other on the Croisette — faith's resurrection and faith's miscarriage — and the second belonged to the exile. In the same year, inside Poland, Krzysztof Kieślowski shot *Przypadek* — the word means "chance" — in which a young man's life forks three ways on whether he catches a train, one branch ending in a mid-air explosion; the film was shelved until 1987. Polish cinema of 1981 theorized Chance on both sides of the border. Martial law, declared on 13 December 1981, closed the argument by force.

Fideicide

The Theology of the Underpass



Anna does not affirm chance; she is delivered of it.

1 *Sister Faith, Sister Chance*

The sequence is recounted by Anna to Mark and rendered in flashback, and it is associated with an ecclesiastical interlude in which Anna stands before a crucified Christ. In the pedestrian passage of the U-Bahn station at Platz der Luftbrücke, carrying her shopping, she begins to laugh; the laughter becomes screaming; her body is thrown against the tiled walls in a choreography that is at once seizure, dance, and combat; milk, blood, and a viscous discharge pour from mouth, nose, and sex; she collapses. Her account names the outcome in the vocabulary of allegory: what she miscarried there was Sister Faith; what remained was Sister Chance.

The allegorical register is not incidental. It is the register of the *Psychomachia* of Prudentius (c. 405), the founding text of Western personification allegory, in which the first virtue to take the field in the battle for the soul is Fides, who strikes down the Worship of the Old Gods. Żuławski stages a psychomachia in reverse: Faith is not victorious but miscarried, and her sister — a figure no Christian allegory admits to the field — survives. Carl Theodor Dreyer's *Ordet* (1955) had given cinema the inverse scene: a woman dies after a catastrophic labour in which her child is lost, and is raised from the dead by faith. *Possession* answers *Ordet* term for term. What is miscarried is not a child but faith itself, and what rises afterward is not the woman but a copy. Because the woman's body is the film's figure for the world's, the event is a *fideicide*.

2 *Pistis, Fides, bona fides*

The faith expelled operates in four registers at once, and the film's force derives from their simultaneity.

Theological faith — pistis, the first of the three virtues Paul names in 1 Corinthians 13 — is joined in Gnostic speculation to Wisdom in a single name: the Coptic *Pistis Sophia* narrates the fall of an aeon called Faith-Wisdom, deceived by a lion-faced power named Authades, the Self-Willed. Anna's miscarriage of *Sister* Faith suggests a Pistis separated from her Sophia; Chapter V follows the Gnostic thread to its end.

Conjugal faith — fidelity — is the film's ostensible subject, and adultery its first miscarriage. *Fides* in Roman religion was a goddess of the given word, guarantor of oaths, treaties, and contracts, in whose Capitoline temple, by tradition, treaties were kept. Marriage, oath, and treaty were held by a single divinity.

Juridical faith — *bona fides* — is the good faith Roman law required of any possessor who hoped to acquire ownership by uninterrupted possession (*usucapio*). Without it, possession never ripens into title. Chapter VII shows that the creature's career is a usucapion without faith.

Diplomatic faith — the good faith of treaties — had organized European détente from the Quadripartite Agreement on Berlin (1971) to the Helsinki Final Act (1975), and collapsed between NATO's Double-Track Decision and the Soviet intervention in Afghanistan in December 1979, months before the film was shot.

The underpass expels all four in a single convulsion, beneath the monument to the airlift of 1948–49 that kept an occupied city alive. It is a domestic, theological, juridical, and geopolitical event at once.

3 *Pascal's hinge*

Faith and Chance are sisters because they share a father. Blaise Pascal, who in 1654 founded the calculus of probabilities in correspondence with Fermat, is also the theologian of efficacious grace and of the hidden God, whose wager in the *Pensées* converts the act of faith into a decision under uncertainty: *il faut parier*. In Pascal, faith becomes a bet; the two sisters are born of one mind. Lucien Goldmann's *Le Dieu caché* (1955) reconstructed from Pascal and Racine a tragic vision in which the world is lived before a God at once absolutely present and absolutely silent. *Possession*'s god is hidden in a flat in Kreuzberg.

The name of the woman who bears Chance is, in Hebrew, *Hannah*: grace. The convergence is exact. Anna — grace — miscarries faith and is delivered of chance; the theology of grace collapses into a theory of probability. Mallarmé's *Un coup de dés jamais n'abolira le hasard* (1897) had declared that no throw abolishes chance, and Nietzsche's Zarathustra had

cast dice with the gods at the gods' table, the earth, until it trembled and broke open — the affirmation of chance that Gilles Deleuze, in *Nietzsche et la philosophie* (1962), placed at the centre of Nietzsche's thought. Anna does not affirm chance; she is delivered of it.

4 *Kierkegaard's demonic*

In *The Concept of Anxiety* (1844), Kierkegaard defines the demonic as anxiety about the good: an unfreedom that closes itself off, which he calls *inclosing reserve* (*det Indesluttede*), and whose temporal form is *the sudden* — the demonic irrupts without continuity. Both determinations are realized in the film with almost diagrammatic literalness. Anna's inclosing reserve is an architecture: a locked flat in a derelict building, where her secret lives and grows. Her convulsions are the sudden: nothing prepares them, and nothing follows from them by transition.

Fear and Trembling (1843) complicates the diagnosis. There the demonic is the shadow of the knight of faith: both stand outside the universal, the ethical, and cannot explain themselves to it; from the outside, Abraham on Moriah and the demonic are indistinguishable. Anna, who will not or cannot explain herself to her husband, occupies exactly this undecidable position, and the film refuses to resolve it. Its theology is suspended between a teleological suspension of the ethical and a possession. *The Sickness unto Death* (1849) supplies the final term: the self is a relation that relates itself to itself, and despair is the misrelation of that relation — at its most intense, the demonic despair that wills defiantly to be itself. The double is that misrelation externalized: the self's relation to itself given its own body.

5 *After the death of God*

In §125 of *The Gay Science* (1882), a madman runs into the marketplace with a lantern in broad daylight, crying that God is dead and that we have killed him, and is met with laughter; he concludes that he has come too early. The underpass is that marketplace emptied of witnesses. Anna's

laughter and screaming are the two voices of the scene — the crowd's and the madman's — in a single throat; the deed is announced to no one.

Dostoevsky's *Demons* (1871–72) — known in French as *Les Possédés*, the title Albert Camus kept for his stage adaptation of 1959, and the novel Żuławski would stage within *La Femme publique* — supplies the next step. Kirillov reasons that if there is no God he must himself become God, and that his suicide will prove his self-will. *Possession* refuses the Kirillovian conclusion: after the death of faith, divinity passes neither to the self nor to its suicide but to what the self gestates. Jacques Monod, closing *Le Hasard et la Nécessité* (1970), pronounced that "l'ancienne alliance est rompue" — the ancient covenant is broken — and that man knows himself alone in the universe's unfeeling immensity, out of which he emerged by chance. Monod's covenant is Anna's *fides*; his chance is her sister. The film's theology was the scientific common sense of its decade.

Charles Sanders Peirce had gone further. His *tychism* held that absolute chance is a real and operative factor in the universe; his essay "Evolutionary Love" (1893) distinguished three modes of evolution — *tychasm*, by fortuitous variation; *anancasm*, by mechanical necessity; *agapasm*, by creative love. The creature evolves by Sister Chance and by Anna's love at once. Chapter V shows that its ontogeny is Peircean.

6 *Heinrich, or the pill of Murti-Bing*

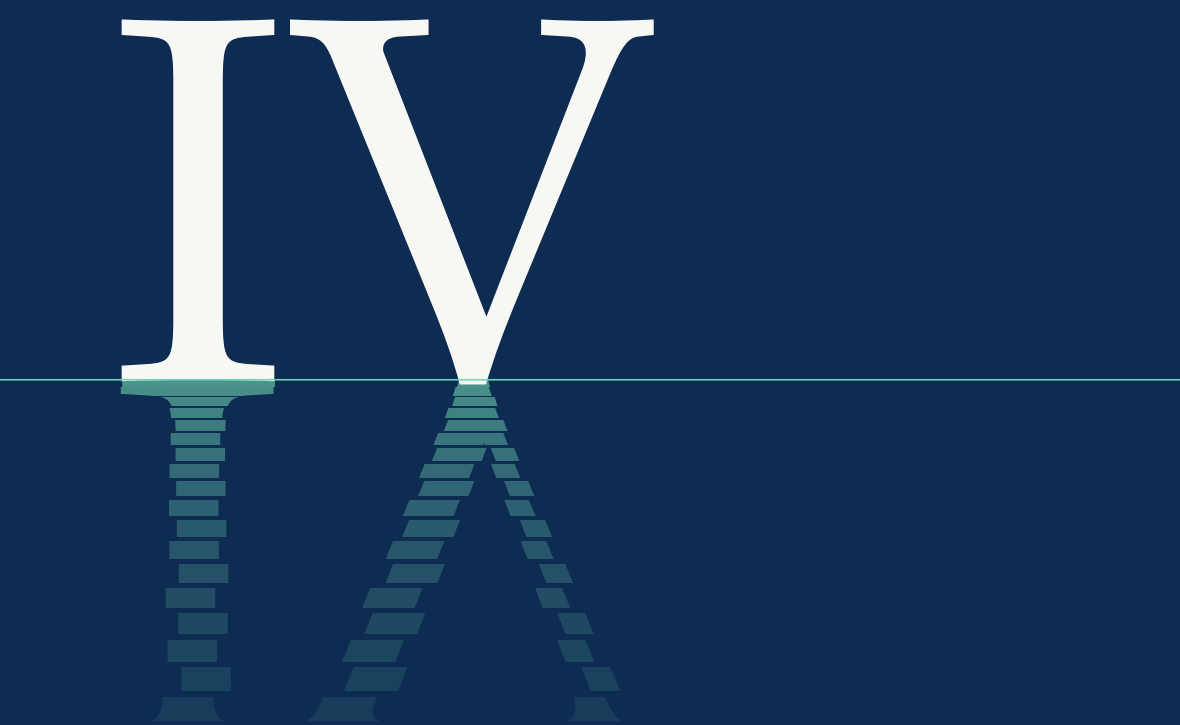
Heinrich is the film's rival theologian. His discourse is a syncretic monism of energies, his body a trained instrument of Eastern martial disciplines, his home shared with his mother. He speaks of Anna with a serene proprietorship that is the spiritualized form of Mark's legal one, and he defeats Mark in the flesh with the ease of a body that has abolished conflict within itself. In the film's theological economy he offers the false resolution: a religion without faith and without chance — a technique of serenity, the Murti-Bing pill of the Western 1970s.

Anna leaves him as she left Mark; the spiritual market cannot absorb fideicide. Heinrich does not survive proximity to what Anna harbours. He dies at Mark's hands, his head held down in a lavatory bowl: a bap-

tism in the city's waste, the degraded sacrament of a degraded religion. Between the husband's legal possession and the guru's spiritual possession, the film interposes a third that neither can survive — possession by what Anna has borne.

The Convulsive Archive

Hysteria, Abjection, Ecstasy



The film is the case history psychoanalysis did not write: the pseudocyesis that delivers.

1 *The wandering animal*

The oldest Western theory of hysteria is already a theory of possession by an animal. In the *Timaeus* (91b–d), Plato describes the womb as a living creature (*zōon*) within the woman, desirous of childbearing, which, if left barren beyond its season, grows vexed and wanders through the body, obstructing breath and inducing every kind of disorder. The tradition that derived *hysteria* from *hystera* inherited the figure: an animal within an animal, with desires of its own.

Possession literalizes the *Timaeus*. Its creature is the hysterical animal exteriorized — an organism of generative desire that has left the woman's body altogether and taken up residence in another apartment, where it is fed, couples, and grows. The film does not represent hysteria as the symptom of a wandering womb; it represents the wandering womb as an independent being with its own address.

2 *Anna O.*

The founding case of psychoanalysis bears the protagonist's name. In Breuer and Freud's *Studies on Hysteria* (1895), "Anna O." — Bertha Pappenheim — christened her treatment the "talking cure" and "chimney-sweeping." The case's legend, transmitted by Ernest Jones in 1953 from Freud's later recollection, adds an ending absent from the published history: Breuer, summoned to his patient, found her in the throes of a phantom childbirth announcing the arrival of his child, and fled. Henri Ellenberger (1970) and Mikkel Borch-Jacobsen (1995) have shown how little the legend rests on, but its persistence is itself a datum: psychoanalysis remembers its origin as a phantom pregnancy from which the physician ran away.

Possession's Anna carries the phantom pregnancy to term. Mark — an intelligence agent, a professional of the debriefing, which is the state's talking cure — demands that she speak; she convulses. The film is the case history psychoanalysis did not write: the pseudocyesis that delivers.

3 *The Salpêtrière in the U-Bahn*

Jean-Martin Charcot's *grande hystérie*, codified by Paul Richer (1881; second edition 1885), unfolds in four periods, and the underpass sequence traverses them with a fidelity that may be inherited from the iconographic culture of cinema as much as from any clinical source.

Richer's period	Clinical description	The underpass
1. Epileptoid	tonic rigidity, clonic jerking, loss of control	the interruption of walking; the body seized and jerked
2. Clownism (*grands mouvements*)	violent contortions, the *arc de cercle*	the body hurled against the walls; contortion
3. *Attitudes passionnelles*	hallucinated scenes: ecstasy, terror, eroticism, crucifixion	laughter alternating with screaming; quasi-orgasmic writhing
4. Terminal delirium	resolution, weeping, collapse	the issue of fluids; prostration

Georges Didi-Huberman's *Invention de l'hystérie* (1982) showed how the *Iconographie photographique de la Salpêtrière* produced the hysteric it claimed merely to record, the patient Augustine performing her attitudes for the camera and for the public lessons. The underpass is a Tuesday lesson without an amphitheatre: no physicians, scarcely a witness, only the camera, which circles. In 1887 Charcot and Richer published *Les Démoniaques dans l'art*, diagnosing the possessed of religious painting retrospectively as hysterics — medicine's annexation of the demonic. *Possession* reverses the vector. Its convulsion produces a being that kills, feeds, and acquires a face. The film re-demonizes hysteria: a counter-Charcotian gesture that returns to the female body the ontological productivity psychiatry had confiscated.

4 *Counter-conduct*

In the lectures published as *Les Anormaux* (delivered 1974–75), Michel Foucault distinguished possession from witchcraft and located its emergence inside the convents of the Counter-Reformation, as the counter-effect of new pastoral technologies of exhaustive confession and spiritual direction. The possessed body's convulsion is, on this account, the flesh's resistance to the obligation to say everything: the plastic, visible form of a struggle waged in the body against the demand for total discourse. Michel de Certeau's *La Possession de Loudun* (1970) had already shown the possessed nuns' speech as a discourse spoken from the place of the other, staged in a theatre of exorcism that was also a theatre of the state.

The film's world is a regime of total extraction. Mark works for an agency whose business is debriefing; he hires detectives; from a watch-tower beyond the Wall a border guard keeps watch over the neighbourhood of the flat. The convulsion is the counter-conduct of a body that cannot be debriefed. The detectives — prosthetic eyes of the husband — enter the flat and die there. Euripides had given the scene its form in the *Bacchae* (405 BCE): Pentheus, the king who would police the maenads, disguises himself to spy on their rites and is torn apart by his own mother. The penalty for looking is dismemberment.

5 *The abject and the monstrous-feminine*

Mary Douglas's *Purity and Danger* (1966) defined dirt as matter out of place and read the Levitical abominations as anomalies in a system of classification: among them, every creature of the waters that "hath not fins and scales" (Leviticus 11:10). The film's tentacled creature is the Levitical abomination par excellence. Julia Kristeva's *Pouvoirs de l'horreur* (1980) — published in the year the film was shot — built on Douglas a theory of the *abject*: neither subject nor object, that which must be expelled for the self to constitute its borders, paradigmatically the body's fluids, the corpse, and the archaic maternal body. The underpass is the most sustained sequence of abjection in narrative cinema: every orifice opens; the borders of the self are discharged in public.

Barbara Creed's *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993) catalogued the faces of female monstrosity, among them the *possessed body* and the *monstrous womb*; Anna saturates both. Carol Clover's *Men, Women, and Chain Saws* (1992) argued that the occult film's true story concerns not the possessed woman but the man who must "open up," abandoning his White Science for Black Magic. Mark's passage from agent to accomplice is the paradigm, carried out to the letter, since the man is at last literally opened — cut, shot. Linda Williams' "Film Bodies" (1991) identified the "body genres" — pornography, horror, melodrama — in which the spectator's body mimics the ecstasy on screen. *Possession* is one of the rare canonical films to saturate all three simultaneously; its excess is generic as well as thematic.

6 *Possession as protest*

Anthropology supplies a counter-reading in which possession is neither pathology nor theophany but strategy. I. M. Lewis's *Ecstatic Religion* (1971) characterized "peripheral" possession cults — the *zar* cults of northeast Africa among them — as oblique strategies by which subordinated women press claims against husbands: the spirit demands what the wife cannot. Janice Boddy's *Wombs and Alien Spirits* (1989), an ethnography of *zar* in a northern Sudanese village, showed spirits figured as foreigners attaching themselves to women's fertility and enclosure — a title that is very nearly a synopsis of the film. Anna's possession speaks what the marriage forbids, in the voice of an alien.

Ernesto de Martino's *La terra del rimorso* (1961) studied Apulian tarantism: women "bitten" by the tarantula enter a convulsive crisis that musicians, dance, and community reabsorb in a rite of reintegration. De Martino's earlier *Il mondo magico* (1948) named what such rites defend against: the *crisis of presence*, the risk of losing one's being-in-the-world. The underpass is tarantism without musicians — a crisis of presence with no rite to receive it. That is why it produces a being rather than a cure.

7 *The holy actor*

Antonin Artaud's *Le Théâtre et son double* (1938) demanded an actor who would be an athlete of the heart, and a theatre that, like the plague, would drive its participants to revelation. Artaud had himself appeared as the monk Massieu in Dreyer's *La Passion de Jeanne d'Arc* (1928), whose close-ups of Renée Falconetti made the suffering female face the privileged site of cinematic passion. Grotowski's *Towards a Poor Theatre* (1968) systematized the total act. Gian Lorenzo Bernini's *Ecstasy of Saint Teresa* (1647–52) supplied the iconography of ecstatic transverberation, and Jacques Lacan, in *Encore* (1972–73), invoked it as evidence of a feminine jouissance beyond the phallus, to which the mystics testify while knowing nothing of it.

Adjani's performance conjoins Falconetti's passion and Bernini's ecstasy under a camera that neither isolates nor contemplates but orbits: Bruno Nuytten's restless movement circles its subject as a predator circles prey. The nearest American antecedent is Gena Rowlands' Mabel in John Cassavetes' *A Woman Under the Influence* (1974) — influence, *in-fluere*, the astral fluid that flows into a person from outside. The performance belongs to the film's theology. By widely reported testimony, the role was an ordeal for its actress; the actor possessed by the part is the theatrical form of the Besetzung complex.

Teratogony

The Thing in the Flat



Horos is Stauros is the Wall.

1 *The creature as event*

Carlo Rambaldi's creature passes through a sequence of states: a bloodied, tentacled, glistening mass in a bed; an organism coupling with Anna; a body sustained, the film implies, by what remains of its visitors; and at last an entity indistinguishable from Mark, save for its eyes. Its development is the only strictly linear process in a film otherwise composed of repetition, relapse, and regression. Everything else in *Possession* comes apart; the creature comes together. When Mark discovers Anna with it, her single word to him — "almost" — is suspended between the erotic and the developmental, and names the creature's telos. This chapter calls its generation a *teratogony*: not a monster's appearance but a monster's genesis, in the sense in which Hesiod's *Theogony* narrates not the gods' existence but their birth.

2 *The Rambaldi triad*

Rambaldi's hands produced, within three years, three of the decisive extraterrestrials of the period. For Ridley Scott's *Alien* (1979), whose visual effects won an Academy Award he shared, he engineered the mechanical head and inner jaw of H. R. Giger's creature; for *Possession* (1981), the creature; for Steven Spielberg's *E.T. the Extra-Terrestrial* (1982), its title figure. The three form a structural set. In *Alien*, the extraterrestrial is the offspring of a rape, gestated in a male body, born into a corporate crew that stands in for the family. In *E.T.*, it is the surrogate for a father who has left a divorced household for Mexico. In *Possession*, it is the surrogate for a husband who has not yet left, and it becomes him. Alien as parasite, alien as child, alien as husband: the same artisan gave form, in successive years, to the three positions the family can assign to the Other. Rambaldi had also built the mechanical figure of the 1976 *King Kong*, the century's emblem of interspecies love.

3 *Lamella and Thing*

In "Position de l'inconscient" (written 1964; collected in *Écrits*, 1966) and in *Seminar XI*, Lacan proposed a myth to rival Aristophanes': the *lamella*, an extra-flat organ that moves like an amoeba and slips everywhere — libido as pure life instinct, immortal, irrepressible life, subtracted from the living being by its subjection to sexed reproduction. Slavoj Žižek has habitually illustrated the lamella by the creature of *Alien*, whose mechanics Rambaldi built. *Possession*'s creature is the lamella with an address: pure libido, indestructible, mobile, given flesh.

Seminar VII (1959–60) adds *das Ding*: the Thing, the absolute Other of the subject, the primordial object lost before it was ever possessed, approachable only by a sublimation that raises an ordinary object to its dignity. The film's spouses stand in opposite relations to the Thing. Anna produces it; Mark finds an object raised to its dignity — Helen, encountered by chance at his son's school. Production and discovery are the film's two modes of desire, and they yield the same result: the ideal copy of the other.

4 *Sophia's abortion: a Valentinian cosmogony in Kreuzberg*

The closest structural analogue to the creature's genesis lies not in horror but in the Gnostic cosmogonies of the second century.

In the Valentinian system reported by Irenaeus (*Adversus haereses* I.2–4), Sophia, the youngest aeon of the divine Fullness, is seized by a passion to comprehend the Father and would have been dissolved into the universal substance had she not been checked by a power called *Horos*, the Limit, whom the Valentinians also named *Stauros*, the Cross, as well as Redeemer, Emancipator, and Boundary-Setter. Her expelled passion, the lower Sophia or Achamoth, is formless and shapeless — an *ektroma*, an abortion — and is only later given form. From her passions the substance of the world derives: from her tears all moist substance, from her laughter the luminous, from her grief and terror the corporeal elements. Irenaeus found the derivation risible. The underpass, with its alternation of

laughter and weeping and its effusion of fluids, renders it with uncanny exactness.

In the *Apocryphon of John*, Sophia wishes to bring forth a likeness out of herself without the consent of the Spirit and without her consort, her *syzygos*. Her product is imperfect and unlike her: a lion-faced serpent with eyes of lightning. Ashamed, she casts it out and hides it in a luminous cloud so that none of the immortals may see it. Its name is Yaldabaoth. It becomes the demiurge, declares itself the only god, and fashions a counterfeit world, including a *counterfeit spirit* (*antimimon pneuma*) by which humanity is misled.

The correspondences are structural, not decorative. Anna produces without her consort. Her offspring is formless at first and progressively formed. It is hidden in a cloud — a flat — that no one may enter and live. It becomes a demiurge whose masterpiece is a counterfeit: the *antimimon* of the husband. And the topography is Valentinian to the letter. The district in which Mark and Anna live takes its name from the hill crowned by Karl Friedrich Schinkel's national monument of 1821, surmounted by an Iron Cross: *Kreuzberg*, Cross Hill. Along its edge ran the Wall. The Limit that keeps the divine Fullness intact by excluding Sophia's abortive passion is called the Cross; the limit that kept the blocs intact ran past the hill of the cross. Horos is Stauros is the Wall.

5 *Pasiphaë's labyrinth*

Classical myth supplies a second matrix. Pasiphaë, wife of Minos, is made to lust for a bull because her husband withheld the sacrifice owed to Poseidon; the craftsman Daedalus builds the hollow cow in which she couples with the animal; she bears the Minotaur; Daedalus builds the Labyrinth to hide it; it is fed with a tribute of Athenian youths. The curse falls on the wife for the husband's withholding — Mark's absences in the service of the state. The Labyrinth is the flat; the tribute is the detectives. And Daedalus, the artificer who builds the apparatus by which a queen simulates union with a beast, is the special-effects designer, cinema's own Daedalus: the film's mechanism of union is literally a Rambaldi device.

Jorge Luis Borges's "La casa de Asterión" (1947) gave the Minotaur a voice, solitary in a house of endless corridors and awaiting a redeemer. The creature of *Possession* never speaks, but it, too, awaits completion.

6 *Enkidu inverted, Salmacis's polyp*

The oldest teratogony of the double is Mesopotamian. In the first tablet of the *Epic of Gilgamesh*, the gods have the goddess Aruru pinch off clay and form Enkidu as a counterpart to the tyrant-king, a match for his stormy heart. The wild man is humanized by six days and seven nights with Shamhat; sexual union makes the beast a man, and the man becomes the king's double. *Possession* inverts and condenses the myth: a woman both makes the beast and humanizes it, and the human form it reaches is her husband's.

Ovid's *Metamorphoses* (IV) supplies the tentacle. The nymph Salmacis, embracing the unwilling Hermaphroditus in her pool, clings to him as the polyp holds its prey beneath the sea, tentacles loosed on every side, until their bodies fuse: no longer two but *forma duplex*, a double form that can be called neither woman nor youth — *neutrumque et utrumque videntur*, they seem neither and both. The octopoid embrace produces the double form. Katsushika Hokusai's print of 1814 in which an ama diver lies in the embrace of two octopuses is the visual ancestor of the film's most infamous image, and Amat Escalante's *La región salvaje* (2016) its evident descendant.

7 *Four modern teratologies of union*

H. P. Lovecraft's "The Dunwich Horror" (1929) gives the hidden offspring and its human twin. Lavinia Whateley's union with the entity Yog-Sothoth produces twins: Wilbur, nearly human, and an invisible, tentacled brother kept in the sealed farmhouse, fed on cattle, growing until it bursts out. Arthur Machen's *The Great God Pan* (1894) gives the Helen. Its Helen Vaughan, daughter of a woman reduced to idiocy by an operation that let her see the god, dies in a devolution through all the stages

of life to a protoplasmic jelly. *Possession* runs Machen's reel backward: Machen's Helen dissolves from woman to jelly; Żuławski's creature condenses from jelly to man, and the film's own Helen stands at the end of the process as its counterpart. Bruno Schulz's treatise gives the matter: a demiurgy without monopoly, a substance of infinite fecundity, a second creation in the image of a dummy; the creature is Schulzian matter that has chosen a form. And Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961), filmed by Andrei Tarkovsky (1972), gives the method: a plasmatic, thinking ocean sends the astronaut a "visitor," a replica of his dead wife composed from his memory, who becomes more human than her model. *Possession* moves Solaris into a Kreuzberg flat and a living marriage. Its plasmatic Other produces the beloved's replica not from memory but from desire.

8 *Evolutionary love and the acquisition of a face*

Peirce's three evolutionary modes describe the creature's ontogeny with unusual precision. Sister Chance supplies the variation (tychasm); Anna's love supplies the direction (agapasm); the terminal form, the husband's face, is the necessity toward which both converge (anancasm). Peirce's categories map the same trajectory. *Firstness* is quality, feeling, possibility — Anna's convulsion, pure qualitative eruption. *Secondness* is brute reaction, struggle, the shock of the other — the marital war. *Thirdness* is law, mediation, the sign. The creature ends as a sign: specifically an *icon*, a sign that refers by resemblance. Mark′ is Mark's icon. Its evolution is a semiosis.

Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari's *Mille plateaux* (1980) theorized *faciality*: the face is produced by an abstract machine of white wall and black hole — the white wall of signifiance, the black holes of subjectivity — and the task of desire is to escape the face. The creature does the opposite. Desire's line of flight from the conjugal — Anna's flight from Mark — terminates in the acquisition of the husband's face. A deterritorialization is captured and re-Oedipalized: the escape from marriage produces a perfected husband. Berlin, meanwhile, supplied the abstract machine with its literal white wall.

The Law of the Double

Eidolon, Counterfeit, Palindrome



The double is neither insurance nor harbinger. It is heir.

1 *The word born of divorce*

The word *Doppelgänger* was coined in a novel about escaping a marriage. Jean Paul's *Siebenkäs*, published in Berlin in 1796–97 under a title that promises the "married life, death, and wedding" (*Ehestand, Tod und Hochzeit*) of a poor advocate, introduces the *Doppeltgänger* with a footnote glossing it as the name for people who see themselves. Its hero, unhappily married to Lenette, has exchanged names with his look-alike friend Leibgeber and, with his help, stages his own death in order to release both spouses; Lenette remarries, and Siebenkäs weds again. The double enters the German lexicon as an instrument of marital dissolution, and the triad of the novel's title is the plot of *Possession*: the married life of Mark and Anna, their death, and the wedding of their doubles at Helen's door.

2 *The Romantic double and its psychoanalysis*

E. T. A. Hoffmann's *Die Elixiere des Teufels* (1815–16) pairs the monk Medardus with a double, Viktorin, and splits its heroine between the painted saint and the desired victim. "Der Sandmann" (1816) offers the automaton Olimpia, preferred by the student Nathanael to his living fiancée — the text on which Freud built "Das Unheimliche" (1919). Edgar Allan Poe's "Ligeia" (1838) gives the closest Romantic template for the film's women: a dark, learned, passionate first wife whose will outlasts death and possesses the corpse of the fair second wife, the revelation coming at last in the eyes. *Possession* inverts Poe: the fair double outlives the dark original, and the film ends before we learn whether Ligeia's eyes will open in Rowena's face. Poe's "William Wilson" (1839) establishes that to kill one's double is to kill oneself. Dostoevsky's *The Double* (1846) introduces the double as the improved self: Golyadkin displaced by a more fluent, more successful replica who usurps his position.

Otto Rank's "Der Doppelgänger" (1914) opens with Stellan Rye's *The Student of Prague* (1913), in which a student sells his mirror image to a sinister stranger and is destroyed by it. Rank traced the double from an archaic insurance against the death of the self to its modern reversal into

an uncanny harbinger of death, a reading Freud adopted. *Possession* adds a third term to Rank's two. The double is neither insurance nor harbinger. It is *heir*.

3 *The manufactured bride*

Villiers de l'Isle-Adam's *L'Ève future* (1886) gives Helen her exact formula. The inventor Edison builds for Lord Ewald an android, Hadaly, that unites the perfect body of his mistress, Alicia Clary — beautiful and spiritually vulgar — with an ideal soul. Helen is Anna's body with an ideal soul: gentle, maternal, chaste, green-eyed.

Fritz Lang's *Metropolis* (1927), Berlin's own founding myth of the double, supplies the rest. Rotwang built his machine-woman to recreate Hel, the woman he loved, who married the master of the city and died bearing his son; it becomes the false Maria, the erotic and incendiary dancer, double of the chaste Maria who shelters the workers' children, and the lower city is flooded until the children nearly drown. One actress plays the guardian of children and her destructive double; the double was conceived as the replica of a lost wife named Hel; the catastrophe threatens children with water. *Possession* reassembles the elements: Helen the teacher, Anna the destructive dancer, Bob in the bath. Alfred Hitchcock's *Vertigo* (1958), in which a man remakes a woman into the image of a dead woman who never existed, and Luis Buñuel's *Cet obscur objet du désir* (1977), in which two actresses play a single woman while terrorist bombs punctuate an impossible courtship until a final explosion, complete the cinematic genealogy. Unica Zürn, born in Berlin in 1916, recorded in *L'Homme-Jasmin* (1971) her lifelong pursuit, across psychotic episodes, of an imagined ideal lover — the female counterpart of the eidolic husband.

4 *Helen's eidolon*

The deepest stratum of the film's doubling is the myth of Helen's phantom. The lyric poet Stesichorus, according to Plato's *Phaedrus* (243a), recanted his account of Helen in a palinode: the story is not true — οὐκ ἔστ' ἔτυμος λόγος οὗτος — she never sailed in the well-benched ships, never came to the towers of Troy. In Euripides' *Helen* (412 BCE), Hera fashions a breathing *eidolon* of Helen out of the sky and gives it to Paris; Greeks and Trojans die for an image while the real Helen, chaste, waits in Egypt. The war of the world is fought over a copy.

Leda, in the version that assigns her daughters different fathers, lay with the god in the form of a swan and with her husband on the same night, and bore Helen, daughter of the god, and Clytemnestra, daughter of the husband — the beauty for whom Troy burned and the wife who killed her husband in his bath. *Possession*'s two Adjanis are Leda's daughters: the ideal one and the mortal, murderous one; and the bath recurs, from Heinrich's death in a lavatory bowl to Bob's final submersion. Helen is the name the film's genealogy reserves for the double: Helena and Marta in *The Third Part of the Night*, Helen Vaughan in Machen, Hel in *Metropolis*, the eidolon in Euripides. The film's last image is the eidolon war beginning: a double at a threshold, and the sound of the world going to war over an image.

5 *Amphitryon in Berlin*

The myth in which a god assumes the husband's form is Amphitryon's. Zeus takes the shape of the absent general to lie with his wife Alcmene; she bears twins, the divine Heracles and the mortal Iphicles. Plautus, in the prologue to his *Amphitruo*, coined the word *tragicomoedia* for it; Molière (1668) made it a comedy of the court; Heinrich von Kleist (1807), subtitling his version "a comedy after Molière," turned it into metaphysical anguish. Kleist's Alkmene, unable to tell the god from her husband, is left at the play's end with a single inarticulate syllable: "Ach!" Anna's screams are Alkmene's sigh extended into an aria; the creature is the god in the husband's form, arriving at last not for the wife but for her double.

Kleist is a Berlin author. His essay on the marionette theatre appeared in his own *Berliner Abendblätter* in 1810, and on 21 November 1811, at the Kleiner Wannsee, he shot Henriette Vogel and then himself: the city's founding *Liebestod*. *Possession*'s couple die together, under gunfire, on a Berlin stair.

6 *Toward eidolic horror*

The Cold War double is ordinarily deficient. The pod people of *Invasion of the Body Snatchers* (Don Siegel, 1956; Philip Kaufman's remake, 1978) are perfect copies without affect; the shape-shifter of John W. Campbell's "Who Goes There?" (1938), filmed by John Carpenter as *The Thing* (1982), imitates without being. These are doubles of lack, figures of paranoia and the enemy within. *Possession*'s doubles are the opposite: surplus doubles, more serene, more loving, more beautiful than their originals — copies without the flaw.

I propose to call the horror they generate *eidolic horror*: horror whose object is the perfected copy, and whose threat is not that the double lacks something human but that it lacks the lack. It differs from abject horror, which dissolves form, and from paranoid horror, which empties it. Its prehistory runs from Stesichorus' phantom through *L'Ève future* to *Solaris*; *Possession* is its founding cinematic text; the shimmering duplicate of Alex Garland's *Annihilation* (2018) is among its heirs. Noël Carroll's *The Philosophy of Horror* (1990) classified monstrous impurity as *fusion* — categorically distinct elements united in one body — or *fission* — one being divided into several, as in the doppelgänger. The creature is both: fusion as a tentacled hybrid, fission as Mark's replica. Eidolic horror is the horror of fission without remainder.

7 *Onomastics: a mark, a palindrome, a constellation*

The film's names form a system.

Mark derives from *Marcus*, "of Mars": the warrior's name for the agent of the state. It is also *the mark* — the trait, the cut, the signifier. Freud's

Massenpsychologie und Ich-Analyse (1921) describes identification as the borrowing of a single trait (*einziger Zug*) from the object, which Lacan formalized as the *unary trait*, the minimal mark of identity. The creature borrows every trait. Mark′ is Mark without the mark.

Anna is *Hannah*, grace — the Hannah of 1 Samuel whose silent prayer, lips moving without sound, the priest Eli mistakes for drunkenness, and who gives her son to the temple. The name is also a palindrome, reading identically in both directions. So is *Bob*. Mother and son, the dyad Lacan places in the imaginary register of specular reversibility, carry the film's only mirror-names; the father carries a mark, which is irreversible. At the end, the last palindrome goes under water.

Helen is traditionally, if uncertainly, glossed "torch" or "the bright one." *Heinrich*, from *Heimirich*, is "ruler of the home" — the man who lives with his mother. The name also gathers a constellation: Heinrich Kramer, author of the *Malleus Maleficarum* (1486–87), theorist of women's carnal commerce with incubi; Heinrich Faust, to whom Gretchen, imprisoned for drowning her infant, cries in the dungeon, "Heinrich! Mir graut's vor dir"; Heinrich von Kleist; Krasiński's Henryk; Gombrowicz's Henryk. The lover who cannot hold Anna bears the name of the inquisitor of incubi, the seducer of an infanticide, the poet of the Wannsee, and two Polish husbands of phantoms.

Kant's Thing

Conjugal Possession and the Juridical Monster



The creature is the adverse possessor of an identity.

1 *Lifelong reciprocal possession*

The *Doctrine of Right* in Kant's *Metaphysik der Sitten* (1797) contains a section devoted to a category Kant regarded as his own discovery: the right to persons akin to a right to things (*das auf dingliche Art persönliche Recht*). Its first instance is marriage, which §24 defines as "die Verbindung zweier Personen verschiedenen Geschlechts zum lebenswierigen wechselseitigen Besitz ihrer Geschlechtseigenschaften" — the union of two persons of different sexes for the lifelong reciprocal possession of their sexual attributes. The word is *Besitz*. Kant draws the consequence in §25: because the acquisition of a part of a person is the acquisition of the whole person, a spouse who runs away, or gives himself or herself into another's possession, may be brought back by the other, as one may reclaim a thing.

Possession is the *reductio ad monstrum* of this definition. Mark exercises precisely the right Kant describes: he reclaims his wife by detectives, by pursuit, by force. But the definition's hinge — the *dingliche Art*, the thing-like mode of a right over a person — carries a consequence Kant did not foresee. A right that holds a person in the manner of a thing will, at its limit, produce a Thing. The creature is what Kant's conjugal right secretes when it is exercised against a person who has withdrawn her will: a *Ding* that possesses. Kant's *dinglich* and Lacan's *das Ding* meet in a flat in Kreuzberg.

2 *Hegel's objection, Benjamin's sobriety*

Hegel, in the *Grundlinien der Philosophie des Rechts* (1820), called the subsumption of marriage under contract a disgrace — *Schändlichkeit* is his word — and defined marriage instead as rightfully ethical love (*rechtlich sittliche Liebe*), a substantial unity that no contract can found. *Possession* stages the failure of both conceptions. Kantian possession, Mark's claim, and Hegelian ethical love, the marriage as substance, dissolve together; neither the contract nor the substance survives the underpass.

Walter Benjamin's essay on Goethe's *Elective Affinities* (1924–25) is notable for declining the customary derision of Kant's definition, treating it as a rigorous registration of marriage's material content — the essay's

opening distinction is precisely between material content (*Sachgehalt*) and truth content (*Wahrheitsgehalt*) — while insisting that marriage's truth lies elsewhere. Its central argument is that when marriage loses its foundation, the legal form that remains becomes the site of mythic forces: fate, guilt, sacrifice. The world of the novel is mythic because its marriage is hollow. *Possession* gives Benjamin's thesis a body. When Fides departs, what remains of the marriage is pure possession, and possession without faith is mythic: it summons a monster.

3 *Corpus and animus*

Friedrich Carl von Savigny's *Das Recht des Besitzes* (1803), the founding text of modern possessory doctrine, analysed Roman *possessio* into two elements: *corpus*, physical control of the thing, and *animus*, the will to hold it as one's own (*animus domini*). Rudolf von Jhering's *Der Besitzwille* (1889) attacked the primacy of the subjective element and proposed an objective theory. The juridical analysis turns out to be a demonology. In demonic possession, an alien *animus* occupies a *corpus* not its own. In Kant's marriage, each spouse holds the other's *corpus* with his own *animus*. The marriage is structurally a possession in the demonological sense; the demon merely makes the structure visible. The creature marks the moment at which corpus and animus come apart: Anna's animus invested in a body not hers, Mark's corpus reproduced around an animus not his.

4 *Usucapion without faith*

Roman law allowed a possessor to become owner through uninterrupted possession for a statutory period — *usucapio* — on five conditions, compressed by the medieval jurists into a mnemonic: *res habilis, titulus, fides, possessio, tempus*. The thing must be capable of acquisition; there must be a just title; there must be good faith; there must be possession; time must run. Without *fides*, nothing ripens. And a maxim the *Digest* attributes to the ancients (41.2.3.19) forbids the possessor to transform the character

of his own holding: *neminem sibi ipsum causam possessionis mutare posse* — no one can change for himself the cause of his possession.

The creature violates both principles. It acquires in bad faith, after fideicide; and it changes the cause of its possession on its own authority, from Anna's secret to Mark's successor, from a held thing to a holder of title. It is a juridical monster in the strict sense — a possession that converts itself into dominion without faith — and it appears as a monster *because* it is legally impossible. The common law knows the nearest analogue as *adverse possession*: a holding that is open, notorious, continuous, exclusive, and hostile, which, if maintained long enough, transfers title to the occupier. It is the squatter's doctrine. In 1980–81 the squatters of Kreuzberg articulated precisely this logic of occupation as entitlement under the name *Instandbesetzung*, repair-squatting. The creature is the adverse possessor of an identity.

5 *The child of imaginary adultery*

Goethe's *Die Wahlverwandtschaften* (1809) supplies the conjugal chemistry. Its marriage — Eduard and Charlotte — is dissolved by elective affinities explicitly modelled on the chemists' double displacement, AB + CD → AD + BC. The child conceived in the marriage bed is conceived in a double adultery of the imagination, each spouse thinking of an absent beloved, and is born bearing the features of the Captain and the eyes of Ottilie: the child of the imagined partners, not of the real ones. It drowns in the lake, slipping from Ottilie's arms as she crosses the water.

Possession's creature is a *Wahlverwandtschaften* child: conceived of desire for an imagined partner, it bears the features of an ideal Mark. The chemistry completes itself in the final scene — Mark + Anna → Mark′ + Helen — and, as in Goethe, a child goes into the water.

The Divided City

Espionage, Deterrence, and Mutually Assured Destruction



Sister Chance is Thomas Schelling's chance; Anna's convulsion is Friedrich Schelling's ground.

1 *Besatzung*

West Berlin in 1980 was the only Western metropolis that was, in law, occupied territory. Its sectors remained under the supreme authority of the three Western Allies within the four-power status reaffirmed by the Quadripartite Agreement of September 1971; it was not governed as an ordinary Land of the Federal Republic; and its male residents were exempt from West German conscription. That exemption drew to Kreuzberg a population of draft-avoiders, artists, and militants, and, in 1979–81, a squatting movement that occupied tenements left vacant for demolition in the shadow of the Wall. Heinrich's milieu is a product of occupation law. The *Besatzung* is the frame of every *Besetzung* in the film: the occupied city hosts the occupied house, the occupied marriage, the occupied body.

2 *Topography of a passion*

The film's places are allegories that need not be read as such, because they are named. *Kreuzberg*: Cross Hill. *Platz der Luftbrücke*: Airlift Square, named in 1949 for the airlift that supplied the blockaded western sectors, its memorial of 1951 rising in three ribs toward the west for the three air corridors. Anna's convulsion takes place beneath the monument to the umbilical cord of the occupied city. The faith miscarried there is also the faith that kept the city alive.

The film's dominant colour is blue — the blue of Anna's dress in the underpass and of its wintry light — a blue German still calls *Berliner Blau*. By the standard account, the pigment was produced by accident in a Berlin colour-maker's workshop around 1706, from potash contaminated with an animal oil distilled from blood and bone and associated with Johann Konrad Dippel, the alchemist born at Burg Frankenstein; and it was from Prussian blue that Carl Wilhelm Scheele first derived prussic acid — *Blausäure* — in 1782, the compound whose industrial descendants the twentieth century would turn to mass murder. A colour born of chance and blood, in the workshop of a man who sought the elixir of life, and parent of a poison: the blue in which *Possession* is bathed is Berlin's own.

3 *The spy as husband*

Mark returns from a mission at the film's opening, is debriefed by an agency he wishes to leave, and is pursued by its emissaries to the end. John le Carré's *Tinker Tailor Soldier Spy* (1974), televised by the BBC in 1979, had made the spy's marriage the hinge of Cold War betrayal: George Smiley's wife Ann is the lover of Bill Haydon, the mole, the affair engineered by Moscow to cloud her husband's judgement. The wife's adultery opens the house to the enemy's double. *Possession* follows the structure to its metaphysical limit: the lover is not a double agent but a double. Miłosz's *Ketman* — the art of a double life lived under surveillance — is the spy's professional ethic, and the film shows what it costs when brought home.

The film's surveillance is a chain without a summit. A border guard watches from beyond the Wall; Mark's agency watches Mark; Mark's detectives watch Anna; the camera watches them all. Only the creature is never a watcher, only watched — and its watchers die.

4 *The two Schellings*

Two thinkers named Schelling bracket the film's metaphysics. Friedrich Wilhelm Joseph Schelling, in the *Philosophische Untersuchungen über das Wesen der menschlichen Freiheit* (1809), posited in God a *ground* that is not God himself, and in all things an unruliness that order never abolishes: "immer liegt noch im Grunde das Regellose, als könnte es einmal wieder durchbrechen" — the unruly lies ever in the ground, as if it could break through once again. Evil is the ground's self-assertion against the order it supports. Schelling lectured in Berlin from 1841, to an audience that included Kierkegaard, Engels, Bakunin, and Burckhardt; Slavoj Žižek's *The Indivisible Remainder* (1996) made the unruly ground the remainder that never dissolves into order. The underpass is the unruly breaking through.

Thomas C. Schelling, in *The Strategy of Conflict* (1960), gave deterrence its most refined formulation in a chapter entitled "The Threat That Leaves Something to Chance": a credible threat need not be a certain one, because deterrence can work by deliberately creating a risk of catastrophe

that neither party fully controls. Brinkmanship is the manipulation of shared risk. *Arms and Influence* (1966) opened with "the diplomacy of violence."

The coincidence of names is no argument, but it is a constellation. The first Schelling names the ground that breaks through; the second names the administration of chance that the marriage of the blocs had become. Sister Chance is Thomas Schelling's chance; Anna's convulsion is Friedrich Schelling's ground.

5 *The commitment device*

Thomas Schelling's theory of commitment holds that bargaining power is gained by visibly binding oneself: burning one's bridges or, in the game of "chicken," to which Bertrand Russell had compared nuclear brinkmanship in 1959, throwing the steering wheel out of the window. The film's most notorious domestic scene follows the theory to the letter. Anna cuts her own neck with an electric carving knife; Mark answers by cutting his own arm. Self-wounding functions as a costly signal, a demonstration that one will bear any cost and therefore cannot be deterred. The exchange is tit-for-tat escalation conducted on one's own body. The marriage's logic is deterrence's — each partner must prove himself or herself mad enough not to stop — and the doctrine's acronym, commonly credited to its critic Donald Brennan, names both: MAD.

6 *The escalation ladder*

Herman Kahn's *On Escalation: Metaphors and Scenarios* (1965) arranged the possible courses of a superpower crisis on a ladder of forty-four rungs, from "ostensible crisis" to "spasm or insensate war," divided by thresholds, among them the one at which nuclear war ceases to be unthinkable. The creature's ontogeny is an escalation ladder, each stage a rung, and Anna's convulsion gives the top rung its bodily name. Kahn's spasm and the clinic's spasm are one word for one thing: action that has ceased to be action, the body or the bloc discharging itself without deliberation. The

film recounts its bodily spasm in retrospect and ends on the sound of the strategic one.

7 *Fortuna is a woman*

Machiavelli closes the twenty-fifth chapter of *Il Principe* with an image of chilling clarity: "la fortuna è donna, et è necessario, volendola tenere sotto, batterla et urtarla" — fortune is a woman, and whoever wishes to hold her down must beat and strike her. Hanna Pitkin's *Fortune Is a Woman* (1984) reconstructed the gendered politics of the figure. Anna, having miscarried Faith, becomes Fortuna, Sister Chance incarnate; and Mark, the agent of reason of state, answers as Machiavelli prescribes — he strikes her. The domestic violence of *Possession* is not incidental. It is the political theology of *virtù* against *fortuna* enacted in a kitchen. The film refuses Machiavelli's promise: virtù does not master fortune; the two die together on a stair.

8 *Doppelbeschluss*

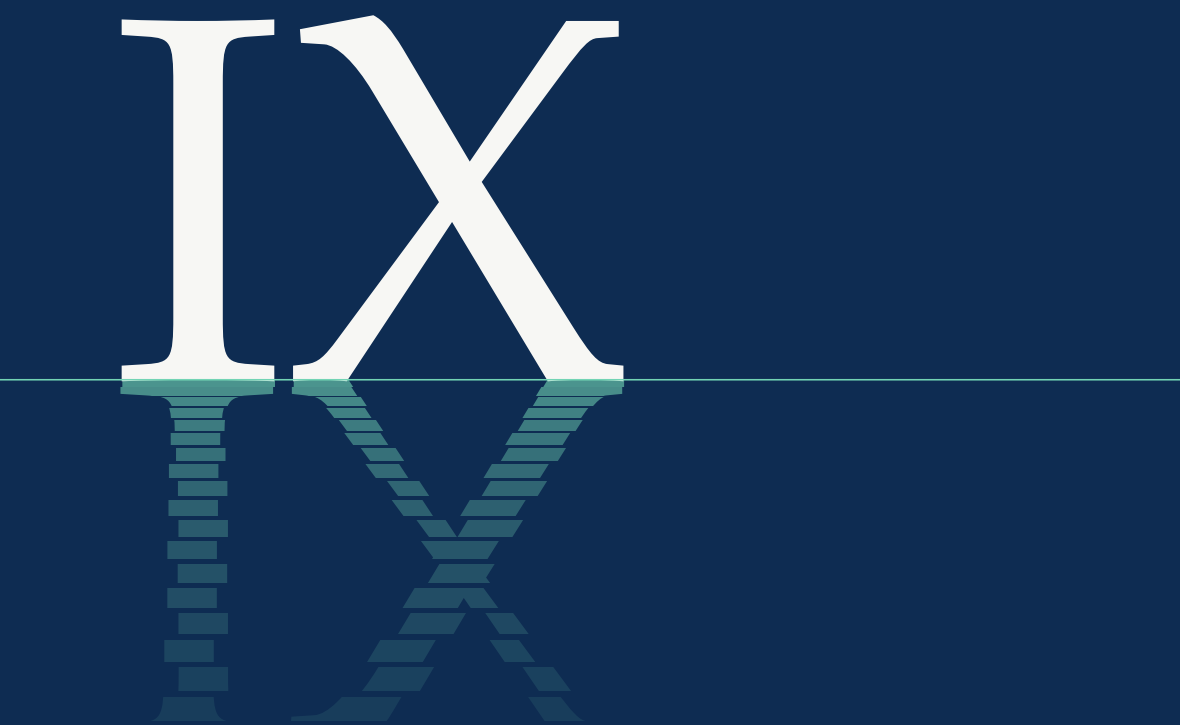
The film was shot in the year between two Decembers. On 12 December 1979, NATO resolved to deploy Pershing II and ground-launched cruise missiles in Western Europe while offering negotiations on intermediate-range forces — in German, the *Doppelbeschluss*, the double decision. Within a fortnight the Soviet Union entered Afghanistan. In August 1980 the Gdańsk strikes produced Solidarity; in November the Krefeld Appeal launched the West German movement against the deployment; in October 1981 some three hundred thousand demonstrated in Bonn; on 13 December 1981 martial law was declared in Poland. The sirens and aircraft of the film's last minute belong to the Euromissile years. The prefix *Doppel-* organized the politics of the period as it organizes the ontology of the film.

9 *Expenditure and catastrophe*

Georges Bataille's *La Part maudite* (1949) held that every system produces an excess that must be spent, either gloriously — in gift, festival, eroticism, sacrifice — or catastrophically, in war; he read the Marshall Plan as a gift that might divert the surplus of American production from war. Anna's underpass is glorious expenditure: the body squandering itself without return, the counter-economy to the spy's economy of information. The ending is catastrophic expenditure. *L'Érotisme* (1957) defines eroticism as assenting to life up to the point of death; the film's lovers assent past that point.

Cinema had already given West Germany and Berlin two images of a marriage's end as a world's end. Rainer Werner Fassbinder — in whose films Margit Carstensen, the film's Margit, had made her name — made a marriage the allegory of the Federal Republic in *Die Ehe der Maria Braun* (1979), which ends in a gas explosion beneath a radio broadcast of the 1954 World Cup final. Ingmar Bergman's *The Serpent's Egg* (1977), set in Berlin in 1923, with Heinz Bennent as its police inspector, takes its title from *Julius Caesar* — "think him as a serpent's egg, / Which, hatch'd, would, as his kind, grow mischievous" — and presents the city as an incubator through whose membrane the future reptile can already be discerned. *Possession* completes Berlin's cinematic teratology: Bergman's egg, Fassbinder's explosion, Żuławski's hatchling.

The Bridal Chamber at the End of the World



At Helen's door the tally matches. But it matches itself: both halves belong to the copy.

1 *The last scene*

After the couple's death on the stair, the film returns to Helen's flat. The doorbell rings. Bob, terrified, cries out that she must not open, flees to the bathroom, and sinks beneath the water of the bath. Helen stands at the door, behind whose glass waits the silhouette of the double. The soundtrack fills with sirens and the roar of aircraft; the image holds, and the film ends. Two green-eyed copies at a threshold; the child under water; the city under the sound of war. Every preceding chapter converges on this tableau, and every tradition the film inherits offers it an interpretation.

2 *Weltuntergang*

Daniel Paul Schreber's *Denkwürdigkeiten eines Nervenkranken* (1903) records the experience of a world that has ended. The people around him are no longer real but "fleeting-improvised men" (*flüchtig hingemachte Männer*), miraculously produced replicas; his body is being transformed into a woman's so that, impregnated by divine rays, he may give birth to a new humanity. Freud's analysis (1911) proposed that the end of the world is the projection of an internal catastrophe — the withdrawal of libidinal cathexis (*Besetzung*) from the world — and that the delusion, far from being the illness, is an attempt at recovery, a reconstruction.

The formula clarifies the ending exactly. The film's apocalypse is a total decathexis: everything once invested — wife, husband, lover, child, city — has been withdrawn from. The doubles are the reconstruction, a world repopulated by fleeting-improvised replicas. In Schreber the two moments are successive; in *Possession* they coincide. The film ends at the instant in which the reconstruction is complete and the old world is still ending.

3 *Cultural and psychopathological apocalypse*

Ernesto de Martino's unfinished *La fine del mondo* (published posthumously in 1977) distinguished *cultural* apocalypses — the eschatologies of Judaism, Christianity, and Marxism, in which the end opens onto a redemptive horizon and the community is reintegrated into a world of values — from *psychopathological* apocalypses: the schizophrenic experience of the end of the world, an end without eschaton, whose echo he heard in the modern literature of nausea and boredom. *Possession* fuses the two, and the fusion is its theological achievement. Its end has an eschaton: the doubles meet, a new couple is constituted, a remnant survives. But the eschaton is counterfeit. The film is a psychopathological apocalypse wearing the mask of a cultural one.

4 *The dispossessed heart*

The closest literary antecedent of the final scene is Henry James's *The Turn of the Screw* (1898). A governess, a figure of chaste guardianship, watches over a boy; a dead man's face, Peter Quint's, appears at the glass, looking in; the boy dies in her arms. The novella's last sentence ends: "his little heart, dispossessed, had stopped." Helen is a teacher; the double appears at the glass; Bob goes under. James's final adjective names the film. The critical history of the novella anticipates that of the film: since Edmund Wilson's Freudian reading of 1934, the question has been whether the ghosts are real or the governess's hysteria. *Possession* answers as James would not: the creature is real, and the hysteria is ontologically productive.

5 *Gadarene water, baptismal water*

The child's submersion admits two readings, both scriptural. In Luke 8, the demons who call themselves Legion beg to be sent into a herd of swine, and the herd "ran violently down a steep place into the lake, and were choked." Dostoevsky set the passage as the epigraph of *Demons*. On this reading, Bob is the herd, the vessel into which the legion passes,

choosing drowning over the door. But submersion is also baptism — "buried with him by baptism into death" (Romans 6:4) — and on this reading Bob refuses the new aeon by entering the old sacrament.

The bath has a long history in the literature of conjugal catastrophe. Clytemnestra kills Agamemnon in his bath; Gretchen drowns her infant; Goethe's child of imaginary adultery slips into the lake; in Henri-Georges Clouzot's *Les Diaboliques* (1955), the husband drowned in a tub by wife and mistress rises from it. The film withholds whether Bob rises. Water is the last element of its cosmogony. If Sophia's tears became all moist substance, the moist substance of Anna's passion has flooded the world down to the bath of a child.

6 *The counterfeit nymphon*

Valentinian theology concluded its cosmogony with a wedding. In the consummation reported by Irenaeus (I.7.1), Achamoth enters the Fullness and receives the Saviour as her bridegroom; the spiritual seeds are given as brides to the angels who attend him, each soul united with its angelic counterpart; and the fire latent in the world blazes out and consumes all matter. The *Gospel of Philip* made the bridal chamber (*nymphon*) its supreme sacrament, the union of the image with its angel. Mani was visited by his heavenly Twin, his *syzygos*; the prince of the *Hymn of the Pearl* receives on his return a robe in which he sees himself as in a mirror, two in distinction and one in form.

The final scene is a bridal chamber. The doubles — the counterpart-angels of the dead spouses — meet at its threshold; the fire of the world is announced by sirens. But the union is counterfeit, because both partners are copies: the *antimimon* of Mark meets the *eidolon* of Anna. Aristophanes, in Plato's *Symposium*, told of the original double humans split by Zeus, each of us a *symbolon*, a tally broken in two and seeking its matching half — the myth Freud took up at the close of *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920). At Helen's door the tally matches. But it matches itself: both halves belong to the copy.

7 *Repetition in Berlin*

Kierkegaard's *Repetition* (1843) sends its pseudonymous author, Constantin Constantius, to Berlin to test whether repetition is possible. He revisits his old lodgings and the old theatre and finds that it is not: the landlord has married; nothing returns as it was. His young correspondent finds repetition instead in Job, who, having lost everything, received everything double. *Possession*'s ending is Job's restitution as horror: everything returned, and returned double, after everything has been lost — the repetition Berlin denied Kierkegaard's pseudonym, granted to Żuławski's characters too late for them to receive it.

8 *The un-divine comedy and the last chapter of the world*

Krasiński's *Un-Divine Comedy* ends with the revolutionary leader, victorious over the old world, struck down by a vision of Christ and crying *Galilaee, vicisti! Possession* offers no Galilean. Or rather, the figure behind the glass is the Galilean's counterfeit: one who returns from the dead in the husband's form.

Kleist's essay on the marionette theatre ends with a proposition about the history of the world. Grace, his interlocutor argues, appears purest in the body that has either no consciousness at all or an infinite one — the marionette or the god; for humanity, which lost grace through reflection, there is no return except by eating again of the tree of knowledge, to fall back into innocence: "das ist das letzte Kapitel von der Geschichte der Welt." The doubles are marionette-gods, grace without consciousness. Anna, whose name means grace, is dead; her graceful copy waits at the door. The film ends on Kleist's last chapter.

Synthesis

Twelve Theses Toward a Tychastic Theology of the Divided City



Anna does not mean something; she makes something.

The preceding chapters converge on a single claim: that *Possession* articulates a theology for which chance is not the absence of the divine but the form in which the divine occurs after the miscarriage of faith. I call it *tychastic theology*, after Peirce's tychism. Its object is a god that evolves rather than reveals itself, gestated by a woman without her consort, in a flat beneath a hill called Cross, and destined to take the husband's face. Its theses follow.

I ***On the fourfold.*** Possession is one act in four registers: to hold (*Besitz*), to be held (*Besessenheit*), to invest (*Besetzung*), to occupy (*Besatzung*). All four are modes of *possidere*, of sitting upon an other. The horror of the film is the discovery of their identity: the husband's claim, the demon's occupation, the lover's cathexis, and the army's presence are a single posture.

II ***On fideicide.*** Every possession is grounded either in faith — covenant, oath, sacrament, *bona fides*, the good faith of treaties — or in nothing. The underpass is the scene in which faith is expelled from the body of the world in all its registers at once. Its location, beneath the monument to the airlift that kept an occupied city alive, makes the fideicide political as well as theological.

III ***On tychocracy.*** What survives fideicide is not a void but a sister. Chance is an order: of the wager (Pascal), of the broken covenant (Monod), of evolution by variation (Peirce), of deterrence by the threat that leaves something to chance (Thomas Schelling). The Cold War was a tychocracy, a peace secured by shared and uncontrolled risk, and the marriage of Mark and Anna is its miniature.

IV ***The law of the double.*** What is held without faith must be held by occupation, and occupation doubles what it holds. An occupied city becomes two cities; an occupied marriage becomes two marriages; an occupied self becomes two selves. Formally: possession minus faith equals occupation, and occupation produces the eidolon. The double is not a symptom of possession but its form under tychocracy.

V ***On the two productions.*** Desire doubles asymmetrically. The wife *produces*: her double of the husband is gestated, evolves, and passes from Firstness to Thirdness. The husband *finds*: his double of the wife is encountered, already complete. The film's sexual cosmology opposes not activity to passivity but production to discovery, and both arrive at the same result: the ideal copy of the other.

VI ***On eidolic usucapion.*** The copy acquires title by continuous possession in bad faith — a juridical impossibility, since there is no usucapion without *fides* and no one may change the cause of his own possession. That impossibility is why it appears as a monster. The monster is the visible form of illegitimate title.

VII ***Mark without the mark.*** The perfected double lacks the mark: the trait, the cut, the wound, the lack that constitutes the subject. It is the ideal ego given a body. Apocalypse is the incarnation of the *Ideal-Ich*: the world ends when the image the subject wished to be takes the subject's place.

VIII ***On horror.*** German *Entsetzen*, horror, belongs to the family of *Besetzung*. The verb *entsetzen* once meant to unseat, to remove from office or possession — *jemanden seines Amtes entsetzen* — and its military noun, *Entsatz*, is the relief of a besieged city. The horror proper to the Besetzung complex is therefore double: dispossession and relief at once. The final scene is both — the subject unseated and the siege lifted, a terror and a deliverance. That is its unbearable ambiguity.

IX ***On the convulsion.*** The convulsion is not the symptom of the feminine but its counter-conduct against a regime of total extraction: confession, debriefing, surveillance. The film re-demonizes hysteria not to condemn the woman but to restore to her body the ontological productivity psychiatry had confiscated. Anna does not mean something; she makes something.

X ***On the Gnostic Wall.*** The Wall is Horos-Stauros, the Limit called Cross that keeps a Fullness intact by excluding an abortive passion. Kreuzberg and the Platz der Luftbrücke make the Valentinian topology literal. The creature is Achamoth in Kreuzberg; but its form is given not by a Saviour but by the counterfeit. In this Gnosis the demiurge makes the husband.

XI ***On eidolic horror.*** There exists a logic of horror distinct from the abject, which dissolves form, and from the paranoid, which empties it: the horror of the surplus double, the copy that is better than its original because it lacks the lack. Its prehistory runs from Stesichorus' phantom Helen through *L'Ève future* and *Solaris*; *Possession* is its founding cinematic text.

XII ***On the missing sister.*** The film names two sisters; the theological virtues are three. The missing sister is Hope — *Elpis*, *Spes* — the one that, in Hesiod, alone remained inside the jar when Pandora lifted its lid and the evils flew out. Anna's womb is Pandora's jar: it releases its evils and keeps Chance, not Hope. The film is a theology of the jar with hope removed. Whatever hope it holds lies in what it refuses to show: the opening of the door.

Conclusion

Mark Without the Mark



That the world should end at the moment he arrives is the film's final proposition, and its most rigorous.

The reading advanced here alters the place of *Possession* in four fields at once.

In *Żuławski studies*, it moves the film from the category of hysterical excess — a style — to that of speculative theology — a thought — and restores its continuity with the two works that precede it: *The Third Part of the Night*, with its doubled Helena, its louse-feeding bodies under occupation, and its apocalyptic title; and *On the Silver Globe*, with its crucified Marek and its messianism destroyed by the state. *Possession* is the third panel of a theological triptych: apocalypse, failed messiah, miscarried faith.

In *horror theory*, it proposes eidolic horror as a category with its own logic. Wood's normality threatened by the monster, Kristeva's abject, Creed's monstrous-feminine, Clover's opening-up, and Carroll's fusion and fission all illuminate the film, but none accounts for its terminal image, in which the monster has become the norm perfected. Eidolic horror names that terminus.

In *political philosophy*, it reads deterrence as possession without faith and the double as the form title takes in an age of occupation. The Cold War is legible as a marriage, and the marriage as a deterrence regime, because both are possessions grounded in chance after the expulsion of good faith; both produce doubles; both end — in fact or in fiction — with doubles acquiring title.

In *theology*, it names fideicide and outlines a tychastic theology: a theology of a god that evolves by chance and love, gestated in solitude and destined for a borrowed face.

The last image of the film is an unsolved equation. On one side of a door, a copy of a woman; on the other, a copy of a man; beneath the surface of a bath, a child whose name reads the same in both directions; above the city, the sound of the end. The figure at the door is Mark without the mark — the husband as he ought to have been, which is to say the husband as no subject can be. That the world should end at the moment he arrives is the film's final proposition, and its most rigorous.

Coda: The Missing Sister

In the *Works and Days*, when Pandora lifts the lid of the jar, the evils scatter over the earth and only Hope remains within, beneath the lip, unable to fly out. Classical scholarship has long disputed whether Hope stayed behind as consolation or as one more evil withheld. Anna's jar keeps Chance. Hope is the sister the film never names.

Walter Benjamin closed his essay on *Elective Affinities* — a novel of a dissolved marriage and a drowned child — with a sentence that could stand at the door of Helen's flat: "Nur um der Hoffnungslosen willen ist uns die Hoffnung gegeben." Only for the sake of the hopeless is hope given to us. *Possession* does not show the door opening. In that withheld image, the one frame the film refuses, the third sister has her only dwelling. Kleist would have called what follows the last chapter of the history of the world. Żuławski leaves it unwritten, which is the only form of hope a tychastic theology can afford.

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Keywords

Andrzej Żuławski; *Possession* (1981); possession; Besetzung; cathexis; fideicide; tychism; tychastic theology; Sister Faith; Sister Chance; eidolon; eidolic usucapion; eidolic horror; doppelgänger; Helen's phantom; Valentinian Gnosticism; Sophia; Achamoth; Horos-Stauros; demiurge; antimimon pneuma; lamella; das Ding; abjection; monstrous-feminine; hysteria; Charcot; Anna O.; counter-conduct; spirit possession; tarantism; crisis of presence; Kant; conjugal right; Besitz; usucapio; bona fides; adverse possession; Berlin Wall; Kreuzberg; West Berlin; Cold War; deterrence; Thomas Schelling; Herman Kahn; mutually assured destruction; Polish Romanticism; Krasiński; Mickiewicz; Gombrowicz; Bruno Schulz; Grotowski; Carlo Rambaldi; body horror; apocalypse; Schreber; bridal chamber; Kleist; Walter Benjamin; Hope.

Nur um der Hoffnungslosen willen
ist uns die Hoffnung gegeben.

Walter Benjamin, “Goethes Wahlverwandtschaften”